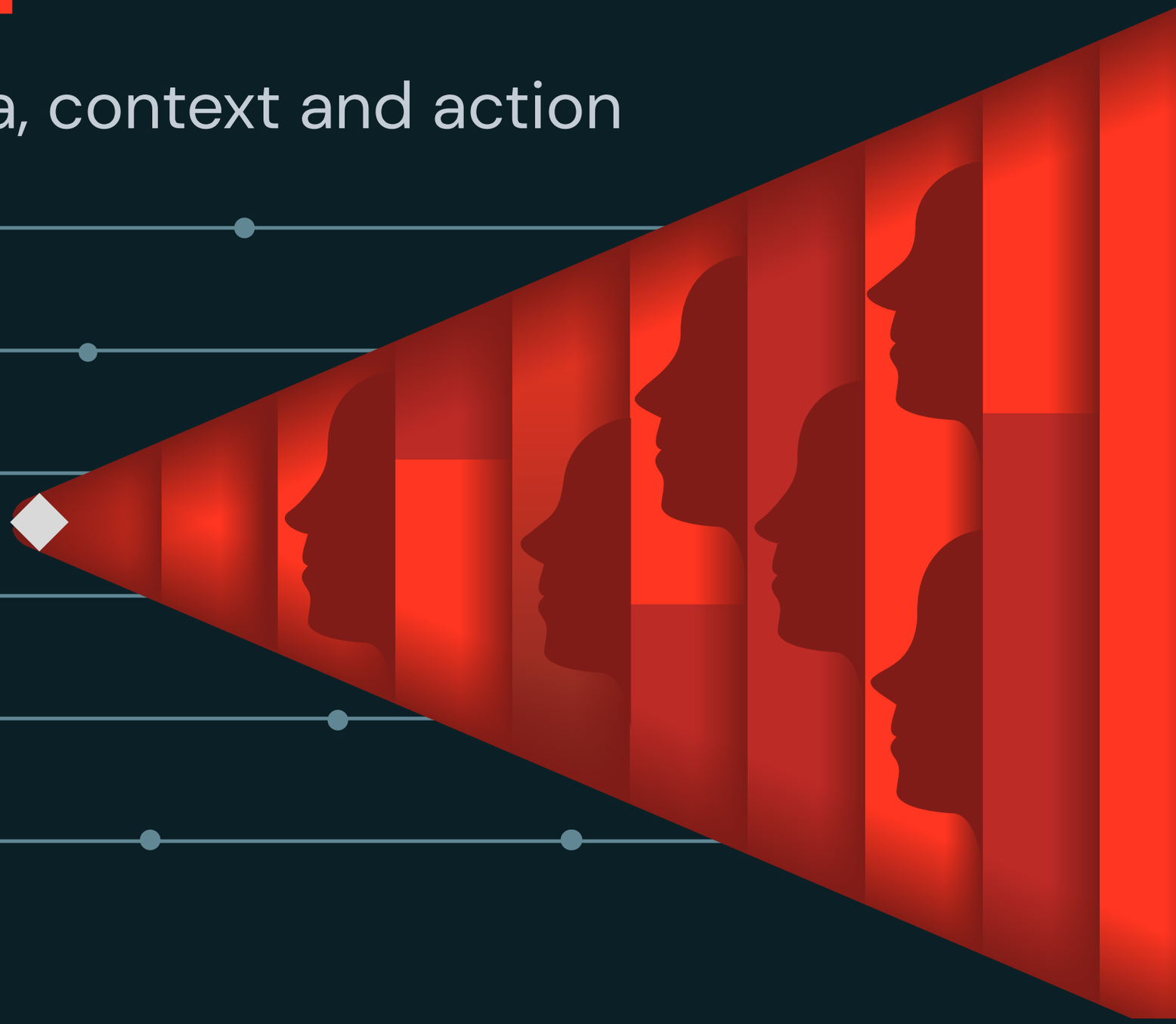
The Data-Smart
AI Coworker

Unlock value with data, context and action



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Contents

Chapter 1: The Hidden Cost of Enterprise AI..... 3
Chapter 2: Breaking Down the Context Tax..... 5
Chapter 3: AI That Knows Your Business..... 8
Chapter 4: Why Governance Is the Unlock..... 12
Chapter 5: Built for Business — The Data-Smart Agent at Work..... 14
Chapter 6: Closing the Gap..... 19

CHAPTER

01

The Hidden Cost of Enterprise AI

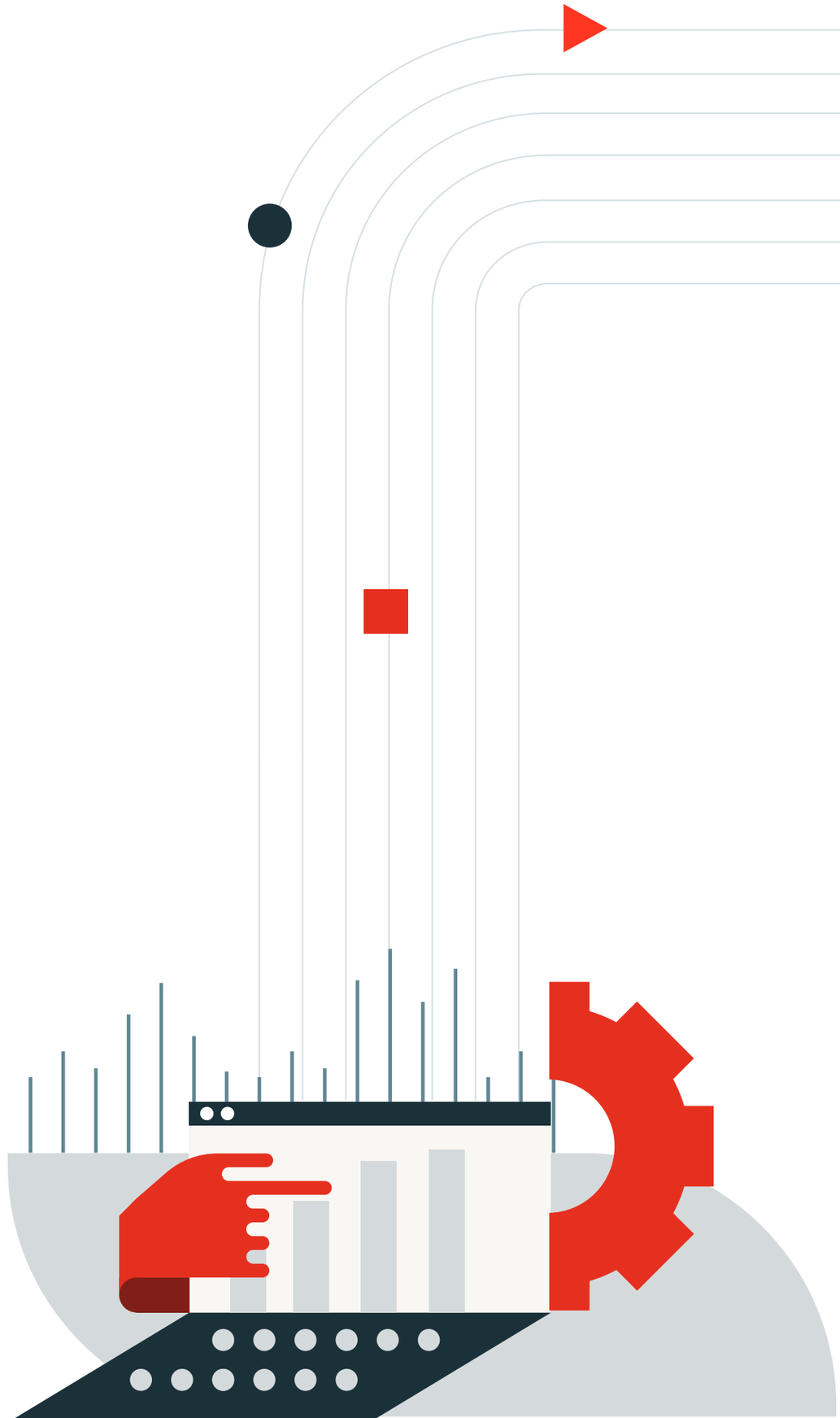


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AI assistants are now everywhere in the enterprise. Teams in marketing, finance, operations and support use them to draft content, summarize threads and handle everyday productivity tasks. AI assistants help move information around faster, and on the surface, it can feel like the future has already arrived.

However, most AI assistants can't handle the harder problems, typically grounded in data, that business users face daily. The decisions that matter most — how to price, where to invest, which customers are at risk, how much inventory to carry — still depend on people who can find the right data, reconcile conflicting sources, understand what has really changed and turn those insights into action. That work remains slow, brittle and takes far too long. Most line-of-business leaders still end up waiting on a small group of overextended analysts to translate real questions into trustworthy answers.

In other words, the people doing that work are paying a hidden cost. Before they can answer anything, they have to figure out what is true. We call this the "context tax."



CHAPTER

02

Breaking Down the Context Tax



If the first problem is that AI stops short of real data understanding, the next problem is why. Enterprise work isn't blocked by a lack of data — it's blocked by a lack of usable context. Before anyone can answer a business question, they have to answer a more basic one: What is true? The context tax is the hidden cost between having enterprise data and being able to use it with confidence.

Ground truth is hard to establish.

In data and machine learning, ground truth has always mattered because every model depends on a stable reference point. Without it, context becomes subjective and outputs become harder to trust.

That challenge is now more urgent than ever. AI systems are no longer just consuming context — they are also generating it, producing summaries, recommendations, classifications and derived data that can quickly spread across systems. Once that happens, organizations have to reconcile not only the original records, but also the new machine-generated interpretations layered on top of them.

This is where many enterprises struggle. Data is scattered across enterprise systems, external applications and tools, not to mention the institutional knowledge that exists in people's heads. It's updated at different speeds and often modeled in inconsistent ways. The same business concept can appear in multiple places, with slightly different definitions, levels of freshness and degrees of trust, depending on which team defines or uses it.

Context is inaccessible to business users.

Enterprise context is widely distributed but poorly accessible. When a business user needs an answer, the hard part isn't finding some data. The hard part is figuring out which source is authoritative and how to connect fragmented signals into something reliable enough to act on. Questions are routed to data or business analysts who've learned how to clean, prepare, join and interpret the relevant pieces. They don't just retrieve answers, they reconstruct the conditions that make an answer usable.

That reconstruction work consumes an enormous amount of time. Analysts spend less of their week generating new insight and more of it resolving metric disputes, tracing stale logic, explaining anomalies and translating business intent into something queryable. The tax is not just technical friction, it's the organizational dependence created when only a small group of people can navigate the context well enough to produce trusted answers.

General AI assistants can't carry the burden.

General AI assistants don't solve this problem. They're effective on broad productivity tasks like drafting, summarizing or reformatting information, but enterprise data work is different. It requires access and judgment about large volumes of structured and unstructured data — what is authoritative, what has changed, what belongs together and what can be trusted.

Most assistants don't have that context. They see fragments instead of the full operating picture. They don't know which table is production-grade, which dashboard the finance team trusts or which document reflects the latest policy rather than last quarter's version. So they produce answers that are articulate but weakly grounded.

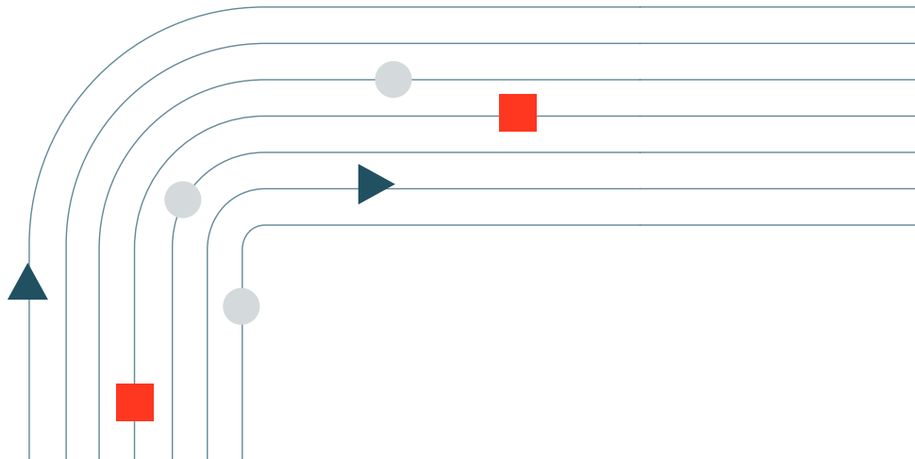
That creates a dangerous illusion of progress. The response sounds complete, but someone still has to validate every assumption underneath it. In practice, this means the hardest work isn't removed, but simply shifted to the people already doing too much of it.

The gap creates shadow AI.

When official tools can't bridge the gap, people look for other ways around it. They paste data into public chat tools, rely on unsanctioned browser extensions or connect ad hoc assistants to systems that were never meant to be queried that way. This isn't usually driven by carelessness but by unmet demand.

The consequence is a growing layer of shadow AI. Sensitive data moves into unapproved tools, auditability breaks down and governance becomes reactive instead of designed in. The bill doesn't arrive all at once. It shows up later as compliance risk, security exposure and decisions no one can fully explain after the fact.

This is why the context tax compounds. The ground truth is unclear. Context is scattered. Analysts become human middleware. Generic AI adds fluency without trust. And when the sanctioned path fails, shadow systems rush in to fill the gap.



CHAPTER

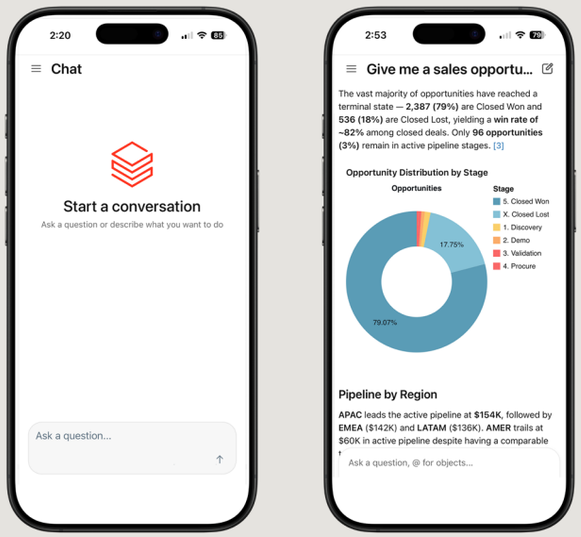
03

AI That Knows Your Business



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The fix for the context tax isn't another AI assistant, but AI that knows your business context. Most of the work that runs an enterprise is data work: forecasts, pricing decisions, pipeline reviews, margin analysis, inventory positions or operational checks. Even the work that doesn't look like data work usually depends on data underneath. And the reason general-purpose AI assistants fail at that work isn't that they aren't smart enough. It's that they aren't built to handle all business context.



Genie on mobile

Genie is the data-smart AI coworker that knows your business.

It reasons over your enterprise data where it already lives, respects the permissions you've already set and shows up in the tools your teams already use. It closes the gap between enterprise context and agentic work.

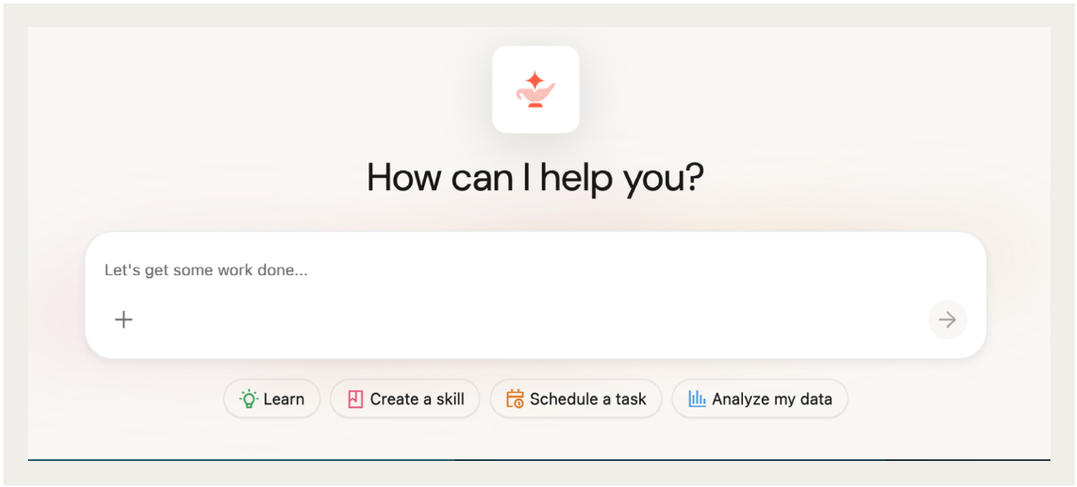
What does Genie do?

1. **AI power for business users**
   Find insights and automate business tasks, integrate into the tools where work happens and build and share no-code apps and agents
2. **Genie Ontology**
   Extract and rank context from usage, improving accuracy, cost efficiency and latency while respecting source permissions
2. **Unified governance**
   Manage connections to external sources, apply business rules to every chat and set cost controls

Three factors make Genie best suited for autonomously handling data work.

AI power for business users, grounded in your business data.

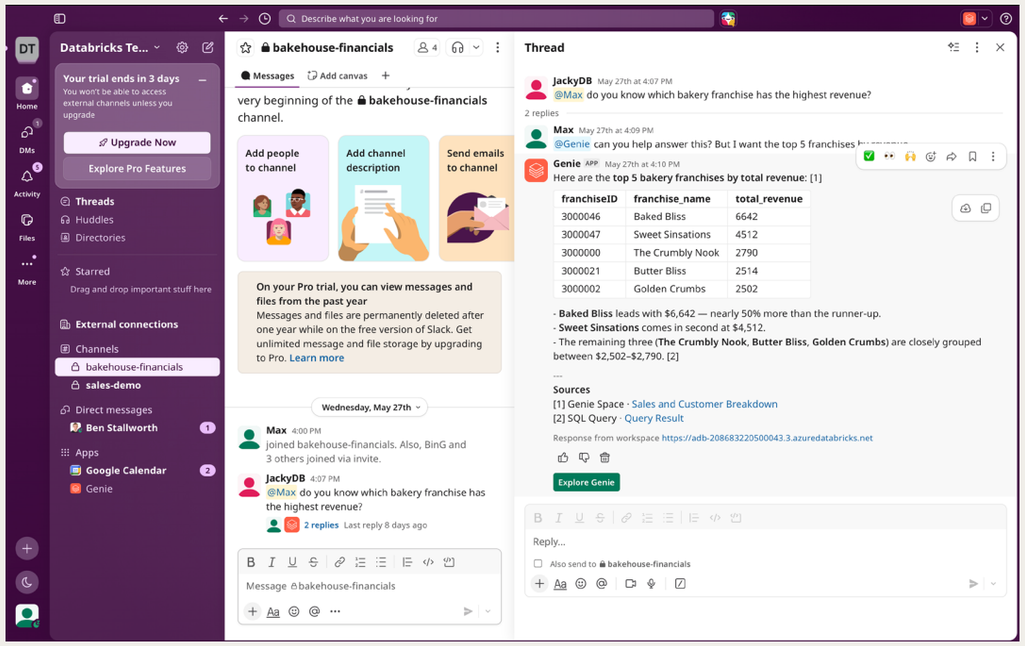
Most AI assistants are powerful in general and unreliable in particular. Genie works with real-time business data: the tables, metrics and documents that already define how your company operates. When Genie tells a sales leader which accounts are slipping, it isn't guessing from a training corpus. It's reasoning over the actual pipeline, with the definitions your revenue team uses, at the moment the question was asked.



One unified home for business users

- **Purpose-built agents.** Genie Agents can easily be created and shared, bringing together data sources, instructions, skills and memory for specific use cases, such as campaign measurement or sales renewals. Analysts set them up by scoping them to the right data and defining the skills their teams actually use, then sharing those skills so others can benefit. Each agent is tailored to its purpose and centrally governed, so users only see the data they're allowed to access. Genie Agents can also generate shareable documents with embedded charts and live data that refresh on a schedule, and handle automated tasks like sending alerts or updating tickets.
- **Genie meets you where you work.** Genie integrates with tools teams already use, including Slack, Microsoft Teams and Microsoft 365 Copilot, so users can ask and answer questions without switching platforms or managing additional logins. It also supports automations, such as recurring metric updates or real-time alerts when values change.
- **Genie enhances collaboration.** Teams can create and share reusable skills to standardize workflows and ensure consistent outputs across projects. It also enables users to turn chat interactions into structured, high-quality documents that can be shared via link, email or PDF, making it easier to communicate insights and keep stakeholders aligned.

The result is AI that gives your business users answers they can act on without calling an analyst to double-check.



Chat with Genie in your flow of work

Always-on enterprise context.

Generic AI tools produce shallow answers because they only see what you paste into them. They have no memory of your business, no awareness of your systems, no way to connect the question to the broader picture.

Genie sees all of it and reasons across your lakehouse, documents, SaaS applications and operational systems as a single live context layer. **Genie Ontology** is a knowledge graph that automatically assembles that context: extracting business knowledge from the assets you already have, ranking information by source authority and enforcing access controls end to end. The analysts who used to spend weeks documenting metrics and join logic for an AI tool don't have to do that anymore. Genie figures it out.

Unified governance across enterprise AI.

The reason governed AI has been slow is that permissions, lineage and policy lived in different places than the data and models themselves.

Genie is governed by the same controls that already govern your data and AI. Permissions flow through and audit trails exist by default. And a unified admin console lets your platform team manage instructions, usage, connectors and access controls in one place.

CHAPTER

04

Why Governance Is the Unlock



In the enterprise, end-user AI does not fail because people refuse to use it. It fails when it slips outside the guardrails that the rest of the enterprise already runs on. When anyone can add an assistant into sensitive systems or move data into tools that were never approved, you don't just lose productivity — you get shadow IT, unclear accountability and new paths to the wrong data.

This is why governance matters most at the point of use. The same controls that determine who can see which tables, which applications they can access and how costs are monitored must apply just as strictly when work is done through an AI interface. Genie inherits enterprise governance rather than inventing a parallel version of it: Permissions, lineage and access are enforced by the same system that already protects the rest of the platform, so the assistant can't quietly become a side door.

Genie governance is the same system that governs your data.

There's no separate Genie governance layer to learn, configure or maintain. Permissions, access controls and lineage flow through Databricks Unity Catalog, the same controls your platform team already uses for the underlying data. When an analyst builds a Genie Agent for the sales team, the sales team only sees what they're permitted to see. When Genie reasons across the lakehouse, documents and SaaS systems, it does so within the access rules each user already has. When an answer is generated, the lineage back to the source data is preserved.

This matters because it's the difference between governance as a bottleneck and governance as an enabler. When governance lives in a separate system from the data, every new use case requires a new round of access design. When governance lives in the same system, the analyst inherits it.

Access controls are enforced end to end.

In Genie Ontology, the context engine that automatically assembles business knowledge from your existing assets enforces access control lists (ACLs) end to end. That means the context Genie reasons over respects the same boundaries as the underlying data. A user can't get to an answer through Genie that they couldn't get to through the source system. There's no shortcut, no inherited service account with broad privileges, no "the AI saw something the user shouldn't have."

For the platform team, this is the difference between deploying Genie to one team and deploying it across the enterprise.

The unified admin console is where it all gets managed.

The Genie admin console provides a single place to handle access, monitor usage and manage costs for end-user AI across the business. It's where admins can onboard new teams, approve or remove connectors, audit who is using what and adjust the instructions that shape Genie's behavior in specific contexts.

CHAPTER

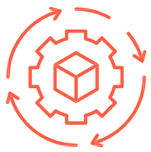
05

Built for Business — The Data-Smart Agent at Work



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Genie is used by thousands of Databricks customers across departments and industries.

EXAMPLE GENIE USE CASES	
 Marketing	Audience segmentation, campaign performance optimization and message and creative testing
 Finance	Explaining budget variances, forecasting cash flow, speeding financial close and handling reconciliations
 Sales	Account 360 insights, deal risk and win-loss analysis and pricing and offer recommendations
 Operations	Identifying process bottlenecks, monitoring SLAs and checking operational compliance
 Supply chain	Demand forecasting, inventory optimization and disruption monitoring and response

While the use cases differ, the pattern across them has this in common: Genie is an autonomous knowledge partner. Analysts curate the governance layer (definitions, metrics and trusted queries), which then unlocks reliable, self-serve data discovery across departments for all business users to make decisions in minutes.

Merchandising at retail scale: From days to minutes

A merchandising team at a major grocery chain needs to make pricing and promotion decisions across an enormous footprint: billions of operational data points, every store, every SKU, every week. The decisions are high-stakes and time-sensitive. The finance team needs explainability before signing off. The merchants need recommendations they can defend in a vendor meeting on Thursday.

The old path took days. An analyst pulled from disparate systems, built a model, walked the merchant through it and then fielded follow-up questions for the rest of the week. The next decision started the cycle over.

With Genie, the analyst builds agent over the merchandising data, including pricing, promotions, assortment and vendor funding, with the metrics the team has agreed on and the access controls the platform team requires. This agent is a specialized merchandising analyst, scoped to the right data, taught the right business logic and governed at the right level. Merchants ask questions directly, in plain language. They run scenario simulations in the conversation: what if we move this promotion to next week, what does it cost us, what does it earn us, which vendors are affected. Every recommendation traces back to the data behind it. The analyst is no longer the path to an answer. They're the reason the answers are trustworthy.

Specialized for business workflows

- Genie reasons over the data the team has agreed on, such as pricing, promotions, assortment and vendor funding, with the metrics and definitions defined in Unity Catalog
- Genie answers questions in plain language and runs scenario simulations in the conversation, with every recommendation traceable back to the underlying data
- Genie governs access through Unity Catalog so merchants see only what they're entitled to see



Enterprise scale: Turning a data team from a bottleneck into a platform

A Fortune 50 manufacturer holds more than nine million data assets in Databricks, and tens of thousands of employees need access to that context to do their work. At that scale, the central data team can't be the path to every answer.

The old path was the one every large enterprise knows: Every question was routed to a small group of analysts. Most employees gave up before they asked or built workarounds that the data team didn't sanction and couldn't see.



With Genie deployed at scale, the central data team builds and governs, and the business teams self-serve within the guardrails. Teams create their own Genie Agents, scoped to the data they own and need to run their business and governed centrally. The platform team manages connectors, instructions and access through a unified admin console. Successful Genie conversations get saved and shared. Employees ask questions in Slack and Teams, in-thread, respecting user permissions. Instead of gating the work, the data team has become the enabler.

Tailored for teams, governed by the platform

- Teams across the business build their own Genie Agents, each scoped to the data they own and skills they use
- A unified admin console lets the platform team govern connectors, instructions and access centrally through them
- Genie answers questions in Slack and Teams in-thread, respecting existing user permissions across every team that touches it

Supply chain: Where every Monday morning starts with the answer, not the question

A global enterprise managing inventory across thousands of materials and dozens of locations needs more than a dashboard. They need to know what's overstocked, what's at risk of stocking out, what it would cost to rebalance and what the second-order effects on service levels and working capital would be. They need that view every week, across every region, with enough transparency that a CFO can understand and trust the answer.

The old path: An analyst built the report, fielded the follow-ups, rebuilt for the next region and started over on Monday. The distribution of reports quickly became a bottleneck.

With Genie, the analyst creates an agent over the inventory and operations data once and schedules automated reports to be sent every Monday morning to the supply chain team with a summary of the positions that moved — those outside tolerance and the recommended actions — pushed directly to their feed or inbox. Alerts fire automatically when a metric crosses the threshold that matters. The company uses this approach to optimize a $1 billion spare parts inventory across 3,000 materials in 50 locations.

Automated, embedded, on schedule

- Genie reasons over inventory and operations data once, then runs the work in the background on a schedule for Monday morning summaries, threshold alerts and recommended actions
- Genie pushes results directly into the team's existing feeds and inbox, instead of asking the team to learn a new tool
- Genie embeds into the planning workflow the team already uses, so the intelligence shows up where the work is, not next to it

Across all three stories, the same roles emerge. The data team builds the leverage. The business team gets the answer. Governance keeps the whole system intact as use cases scale from pilots to production.

CHAPTER

06

Closing the Gap



While enterprise AI has improved productivity, teams across the business still struggle to understand and do the work that actually runs the business. They pay the context tax every day: rebuilding ground truth, stitching together partial views and validating that any answer is both correct and explainable before it can be used.

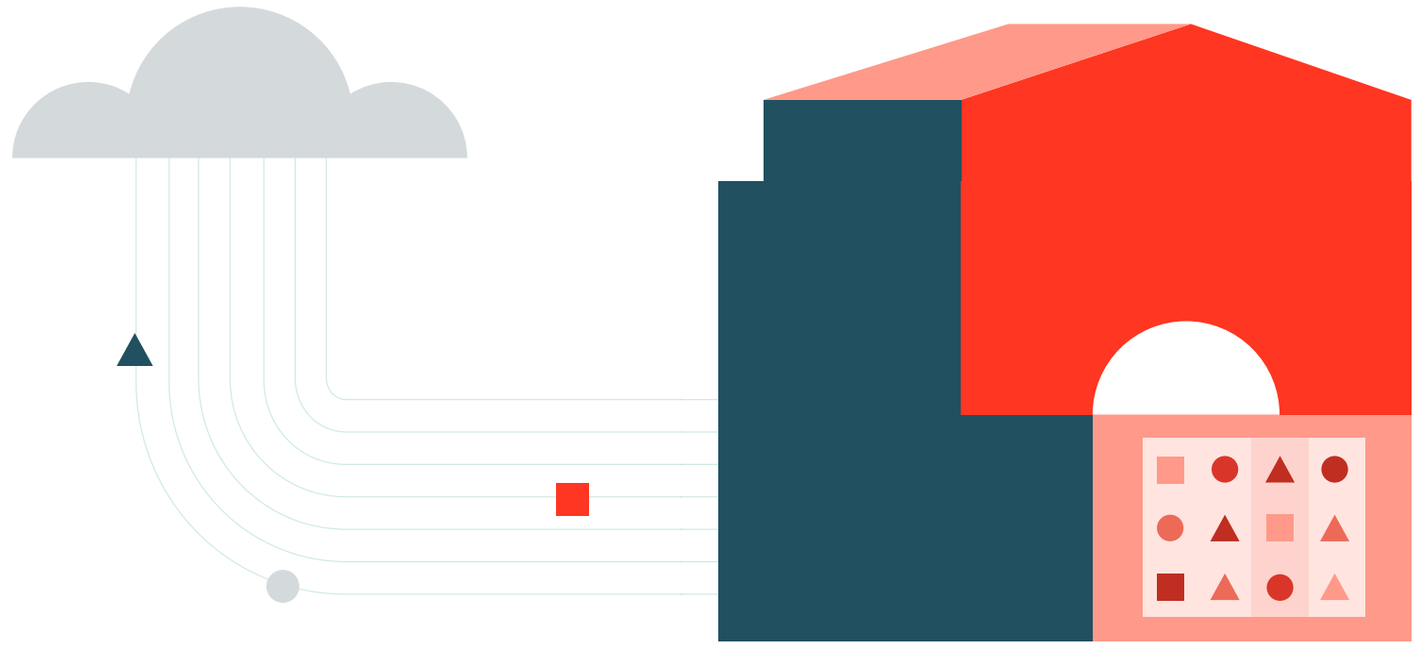
Genie is data-smart. It reasons over business data, assembles context rather than guessing and operates under the same governance that protects your platform today. The result is an AI coworker that can help with real data work, so enterprise teams spend less time reconstructing context and more time acting on it.

databricks.com/genie

Learn how to deliver trusted, AI-powered insights on the Databricks Platform

Learn more about Genie

Learn Analytics Fundamentals in 1 hour



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About Databricks

Databricks is the data and AI company. More than 20,000 organizations worldwide — including adidas, AT&T, Bayer, Block, Mastercard, Rivian, Unilever and over 60% of the Fortune 500 — rely on Databricks to build and scale data and AI apps, analytics and agents. Headquartered in San Francisco with 30+ offices around the globe, Databricks offers a unified Data Intelligence Platform that includes Agent Bricks, Lakeflow, Lakehouse, Lakebase and Unity Catalog.

To learn more, follow Databricks on LinkedIn, X, Youtube and Instagram.



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